

Episode 103: Once Upon a Time... (63) – Release Date Crisis! *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie*

This week brought typhoons, but were everyone's towns and lives okay?

While I feel sorry for areas that suffered damage, I strangely get excited when typhoons approach.

When we were kids... ah, about 40 years ago... when we heard "typhoon," we'd check flashlight batteries preparing for power outages, and during long nights with shutters closed tight, we'd listen to typhoon information on TV and radio, getting excited by phrases like "it made landfall at XX!" as if describing monsters, our tension rising strangely at the sound of wind and rain raging outside, staying up late full of excitement.

How are today's children? Are they relatively cool about it?

I didn't stay up all night chasing typhoon information this time, but if I'd been up all night for work, I probably would have been glued to typhoon reports the whole time without getting bored (laughs).

Now then.

"The release date got moved up a week. So we have even less schedule. Please help!" This was production manager Higuchi-san's opening line to me.

Plus "Tsujita-kun, sorry, please help!" This was Ikuhara-san's opening line. September 1993.

Sudden developments (laughs).

The release date moved up one week was December 5th. Normally there's always a publisher-hosted preview one week before, meaning we had to deliver the complete package by late November 20th at the latest. Hahaha (laughs), exactly two months (laughs). We'd spent nearly two years on COO until then, so wow (laughs). Immediately hellish schedule progression.

Now, such theatrical *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie*, directed by Ikuhara Kunihiko who was also TV series chief director, animation director Tadano Kazuko, art director Taniguchi Jun'ichi. December 1993 release, simultaneously screening with *Make Up! Sailor Senshi* (director: Kosaka Haruna) and *Tsuyoshi Shikkari Shinasai: Tsuyoshi no Time Machine de Shikkari Shinasai* (director: Misawa Shin, production: Studio Comet) - a three-film programmes. The "pillar" work was this *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie*.

As written before, I wasn't involved at all with TV series *Sailor Moon* or *Sailor Moon R*. So I was in exactly the same position as with *Dragon Ball Z* theatrical series, where I also wasn't involved with the TV version. "TV is TV, theatrical is theatrical."

I peeked at episode 1's staff preview, but afterward never watched broadcasts, so I was shaky on detailed story conventions, character relationships... or rather, even the main characters' names (laughs). But there was no time to rewatch TV versions now. So I participated in what you might call a "completely blank state."

First, as usual, I worked on adjusting main character colour tones. Those "Sailor Senshi" costumes.

While "TV is TV, theatrical is theatrical," not changing character impressions from the TV version was essential, so I aimed not to mess with basic "normal colours." I changed "shadow colours" and "highlight" colour tones for skin, hair, and clothing parts slightly to create overall contrast. I adjusted everything just a bit stronger than TV version colour direction.

Around then, many works in the streets gave characters fairly deep shadow colours emphasising contrast, but setting shadow colours too deep would break these characters' "dignified yet soft" impression, so the contrast was balanced to just appear clearly on theatres screens.

Actually, looking at TV version colour direction, shadow colours were set relatively shallow. Furthermore, many main episode cuts in the TV version were coloured and photographed "shadowless."

People who regularly watch TV come to see theatrical versions. So when TV viewers see this screen in theatress, if shadow animation appears somewhat clearly tightened, looking slightly upgraded - that would be OK! I thought of it that way. Same impression as TV, but a bit "theatrical-like" was the target.

Oh yes, these "Sailor Senshi" costumes are design-wise more like figure skating leotards than "sailor uniforms." Figure skating costumes with sailor collars and skirts added. So unlike real sailor uniforms, they're functional, easy to move in, and not sleazy.

"Takeuchi-san's (original creator) concept is really good," I remember Ikuhara-kun admiring.

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